

Portal backend structure

A plain-language map of how the backend is built so far — no code, just the shape of it.

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01 · THE CORE IDEA

Flat and role-scoped, not a matching engine

Each participant type signs up, fills in a profile, and does exactly one more thing relevant to their role. Nobody sees another participant's data, and nobody messages another participant directly — every conversation in the system has a Connectors staff member on one side of it.

If two parties need to be introduced, that happens manually, off-platform, by your team. The portal's job is to collect clean information, not to run the introduction.

02 · PARTICIPANT TYPES

Five types, plus Admin — one job each

Nobody browses, requests, or lists anything outside their one job below. That's deliberate — it's what keeps the system simple.

TYPE	WHAT THEY ARE	THEIR ONE JOB
Brand	A business expanding into new space	Browse Locations — every property landlords/developers have submitted. Read-only.
Franchisee	Someone looking to run a franchise	Submit a request describing what they want. Nothing else.
Landlord	Owns individual retail/commercial units	List properties — the space brands then browse.
Developer	Runs a mall or larger scheme	Same as landlord — lists properties.
Investor	Has capital to deploy	Submit a request describing their mandate. Nothing else.
Admin	Connectors staff	Sees everyone, everything. No organization of their own.

Who can sign up, and how access is gated

- **Self-registration** is open to Brand, Franchisee, Landlord, and Developer. A visitor picks their type, and the system creates their organization and a blank profile together, signs them in immediately, and sends them to a short onboarding form.
- **Investors are added by Admin only** — capital relationships start with a conversation, not a signup form.
- **Onboarding is a gate:** until an organization finishes its profile, it can't reach anything else in the portal.
- **Login uses a signed, tamper-proof cookie** — not a third-party auth service. Every request re-checks it, both at the routing level and again inside each action, so a routing mistake alone can never grant access.
- Admin accounts have no organization attached — permission comes from a simple "is this user staff" flag, checked everywhere that matters.

What's actually stored, in plain terms

HOLDS	NOTES
Organizations	One row per company/account — name, type, status, and whether onboarding is done.
Users	Logins. Each belongs to one organization (or is Admin staff, with none).
Profiles	One shape per type — a brand's industry and franchise terms, a franchisee's budget and territory, a landlord's portfolio, an investor's ticket size, and so on.
Properties	Space listed by a landlord or developer — city, size, rent, photos, video, floor level, parking. The one thing brands are shown.
Requests	What a franchisee or investor is looking for. Visible only to Admin — a queue your team works from, not a marketplace.
Documents	Files or links shared between Connectors and one organization.
Messages	A simple chat thread between Connectors and one organization. No thread ever exists between two organizations.
Enquiries	Raw submissions from the four public marketing-site forms — see the flow below.

How the website feeds the backend

This is the only door from the public site into the portal's real data. A submission never becomes a live organization without a human deciding so.

- 1 A visitor fills in one of the four public enquiry forms.
- 2 It's saved as an **enquiry** — and emailed to your team, if email is configured. Nothing else happens automatically.
- 3 Admin reviews it under **Enquiries** and either **archives** it or **converts** it.
- 4 Converting creates the real organization and its profile, plus — depending on type — either a **request** or a **property listing**.

What the Connectors team can do

- Manage every organization of every type: create, view, edit.
- Review, convert, or archive public enquiries.
- See **every** property listed, across all landlords and developers, in one place.
- See **every** request submitted, with a status updated manually (open / in review / matched / closed) purely for internal tracking.
- Create portal accounts for anyone, with a temporary password — emailed automatically if email sending is configured, otherwise shown once to pass on.
- Share documents and exchange messages with any organization.

Scope boundaries worth knowing

- **No matching or deal pipeline.** An earlier version of this project had a full blind-matching system — staged deals, masked identities, admin-brokered introductions. It's been removed for the simpler model above; introductions now happen manually, off-platform.
- **No organization ever sees or messages another organization.** The one exception is brands browsing the property list, which is one-directional with no reply or contact action attached.
- **No live map picker yet.** Property listings use plain city/country/address fields. Latitude/longitude columns are already reserved in the database, so a real Google Maps picker can be added later with no data migration — just an API key.
- **No direct photo/video upload yet.** Photos and video are pasted-in links, the same pattern as Documents, not a drag-and-drop uploader. Real uploads need file storage (Vercel Blob) wired in.

For reference

- **Actions:** `Next.js Server Actions` handle every write — no separate API layer.
- **Database:** `Postgres via Drizzle ORM`, using a standard connection driver — works with Neon, Supabase, Railway, or any other Postgres host, not locked to one provider.
- **Auth:** hand-rolled — bcrypt for passwords, a signed HMAC cookie for sessions — no NextAuth or third-party auth dependency.